SNOWY RIVER

Turn your hand at the summit.
Chase, or watch?



2–5 players · 10+ · 20–30 min

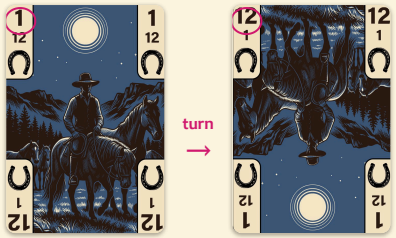
"There was movement at the station, for the word had passed around that the colt from old Regret had got away." The best riders chase the wild mob up the mountain. At the top, all but one stop. The weedy pony from the Snowy goes over the edge, and brings them home alone. Every hand rides the poem.

HOW IT WORKS

A must-follow trick-taking game. **The highest card always wins**, and every trick is 1 point.

- **The climb:** six tricks. The big horses win.
- **The summit:** everyone **turns their hand round**, and the weedy ponies are now the best cards. Choose in secret: **Chase** the mob, or **Watch**.
- **The descent:** six tricks, each with a Brumby card on it. Chasers keep the ones they win.

COMPONENTS



Climb side up
the Home 1

Turned round
now the Home 12

60 horse cards in five suits of 12. Every card has two values that add up to 13. The **big number at the top** is the one that counts. The small number under it is what the card is worth the other way up.

Escape trumps on the climb · **Climb** · **Descent** · **Home** trumps on the descent · **Muster** 5 players only



Mountain: the climb side



and the descent side



Brumby · Wombat hole · The Colt · Chase / · Watch

- 1 two-sided **Mountain** card and the horse-head **summit marker**.
- 12 **Brumby cards**: 5 Brumbies worth +2 and 3 worth +1, 1 Flint stones (−1), 2 Wombat holes (−2) and **the Colt from old Regret** (+4).
- 5 **Chase / Watch** cards, Chase on one side and Watch on the other, and a score pad.

EVERY CARD HAS TWO LIVES

A 12 is a big thoroughbred: it wins on the climb, and turned round it is only a 1. A 1 is a weedy pony: hopeless going up, a 12 coming down. **Choose which cards to spend on the climb and which to keep.**

SETUP

1. Put the **Mountain** card in the middle, climb side up (the six circles), with the summit marker at the foot of the track.
2. Shuffle the 12 **Brumby cards** into a face-down deck beside it.
3. Everyone takes a **Chase / Watch** card. The player who last rode a horse is the first **dealer**.
4. With 2–4 players, leave the **Muster** suit in the box. Shuffle the horse cards and **deal 12 each**. Any cards left over stay out, face down and unseen.
5. Pick up your hand with the **pictures the right way up**. Never turn a single card round.

Players	Horse cards	Left out	Hands in a game	Chase costs
2	48	24	3	3
3	48	12	3	2
4	48	0	4	2
5	60	0	5	2

THE CLIMB: 6 TRICKS

The player on the dealer's left leads the first trick with any card. Then each player in turn, clockwise, plays one card face up.

1. Follow

If you have a card of the **led suit**, you must play one. If you can't, play any card.

2. Highest wins

Escape is trumps. If any Escape cards were played, the highest Escape wins. If not, the **highest card of the led suit** wins.

3. Take the trick

The winner puts the trick face down in front of them: it is worth **1 point**. They move the summit marker up **one circle** and lead the next trick.

EXAMPLE: A CLIMB TRICK



1 Alan leads the Climb 12, the best card in the suit. Loretta and Jean must follow.

2 Charles has no Climb cards, so he may play anything. He plays the Escape 1.

3 A trump doesn't have to be led. It is the only Escape card in the trick, so even the 1 wins. **Charles takes the trick** and leads the next.

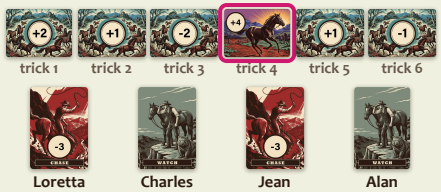
THE SUMMIT

After the **sixth climb trick** the marker is on circle 6. Do these in order:

1. **Everyone turns their whole hand round.** The numbers that were at the bottom now count.
2. Turn the Mountain card over. **Home is trumps** from now on, and Escape is not.
3. Deal the top **6 Brumby cards** face up in a row, left to right: one for each descent trick.
4. Everyone secretly chooses **Chase** or **Watch**. Slide your card under your hand with your choice face up, then all reveal together.

- **Chase:** you keep the Brumby card of every descent trick you win, good or bad. Chasing costs **2 points** when the hand is scored (**3** with 2 players, as the card shows).
- **Watch:** you pay nothing and keep no Brumby cards. Your tricks still score.

EXAMPLE: THE SUMMIT



1 The row is dealt. The Colt is on the fourth trick, with a Wombat hole just before it.

2 Jean's turned hand holds the Home 12 and 11, the two best trumps. She chases, and so does Loretta, who has high cards but no trumps. Charles and Alan watch.

THE DESCENT: 6 TRICKS

The winner of the last climb trick leads. Everyone plays, **chasers and watchers alike**, just as on the climb, with two changes:

- You read the **turned numbers**.
- **Home is trumps.** If any Home cards were played, the highest Home wins.

The Brumby cards

The winner of each trick also takes the **next Brumby card** in the row, from the left.

- A **chaser keeps it**, face up in front of them, whatever it is.
- A **watcher** puts it straight on the **discard pile**, face up.

NOBODY CHASES?

Play the descent anyway. Every trick is still a point, and all six Brumby cards go on the discard pile.

NO COLT?

The Colt is in one row out of every two. A row without it plays just the same.

WATCHERS ARE THE MOUNTAIN

A watcher who wins a trick sends its Brumby card away from the chasers. Watchers fight for the best cards in the row, and leave the Wombat holes to the chasers.

EXAMPLE: TWO DESCENT TRICKS



1 Charles won the last climb trick, so he leads: the Descent 2. On the climb this card was an 11.

2 Jean has no Descent cards. Her Home 2 is now an 11, and Home is trumps: **she wins**.



3 Jean is a **chaser**. She keeps the first card in the row: **+2**.



4 Charles trumps the next trick with the Home 9. He is a **watcher**, so its +1 goes on the discard pile.

SCORING A HAND

When the hands are empty, everyone counts their tricks. Climb tricks and descent tricks count the same.

You chose	You score
Watch	**1 for each trick**
Chase	**1 for each trick** **+ your Brumby cards** **– the Chase cost**

A chaser pays the cost even with no tricks won, so a score can go **below zero**.

EXAMPLE: THE SCORES

	Choice	Tricks	Brumby kept	Cost	Score
Loretta	Chase	2	–2	–2	**–2**
Charles	Watch	4	–	–	**4**
Jean	Chase	3	+5	–2	**6**
Alan	Watch	3	–	–	**3**

1 Jean won 3 tricks and kept a +2, the Colt (+4) and the Flint stones (–1). 3 + 5 – 2 = **6**.

2 Loretta won 2 tricks, but her only Brumby card was a Wombat hole. 2 – 2 – 2 = **–2**.

3 Charles and Alan watched: **4** and **3**.

THE NEXT HAND

Put **every Brumby card from the hand** on the discard pile, kept or not. Pass the deal to the left, reset the Mountain card and its marker, and play again from Setup step 4.

The Brumby deck is **not** reshuffled between hands: the next row is its next six cards. When fewer than six are left (after every second hand), shuffle all 12 into a new deck. The discard pile is face up, and anyone may look through it.

END OF THE GAME

Play **one hand per player** (three hands with 2 players). The **highest total wins**.

Ties: the tied player who scored the most in the last hand wins. Still tied? Share the win.

AT A GLANCE

- **Every trick:** follow suit if you can. Highest trump wins, or else the highest card of the led suit.
- **The climb:** 6 tricks. Escape is trumps.
- **The summit:** turn hands and Mountain, deal 6 Brumby cards, Chase or Watch.
- **The descent:** 6 tricks. Home is trumps. Chasers keep the Brumby cards they win, and pay 2 (3 with 2 players).

THE MAN FROM SNOWY RIVER

A. B. "Banjo" Paterson, 1890. Public domain. From two of its thirteen verses.

When they reached the mountain's summit, even Clancy took a pull,
It well might make the boldest hold their breath,
The wild hop scrub grew thickly, and the hidden ground was full
Of wombat holes, and any slip was death.
But the man from Snowy River let the pony have his head,
And he swung his stockwhip round and gave a cheer,
And he raced him down the mountain like a torrent down its bed,
While the others stood and watched in very fear.

…

And he ran them single-handed till their sides were white with foam.
He followed like a bloodhound on their track,
Till they halted cowed and beaten, then he turned their heads for home,
And alone and unassisted brought them back.

THE WORDS

Mob: a herd of horses.

Brumbies: wild bush horses.

Cracks: the best riders.

Muster: a round-up of stock, and the riders who gather for it.

Take a pull: rein in and stop. In the game: Watch.

Let him have his head: give the horse free rein. In the game: Chase.

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wombatgamefactory.com/games/snowy-river
Rule book v4 · 11/11/2026 · Prototype art